and sixteen hours. She had survived the earthquake, the cold nights and the wild animals. A ragged cheer went up and the soldier wrapped her in a warm blanket and carried her to the tent where a makeshift hospital had been set up. Bhuli lived. The next day I went to thank the Army Officer. But he was gone. I did not even know his name.

My sister and I went on to live with my uncle. Soon after, I got a job at a dhaba near Panipat. Bhuli stayed back. She started going to school. It weighted on me that I never thanked that Army Officer. I hoped that one day I would run into him again. Every time I saw an army man, I would hope it was him. For months I would search for his face in every crowd. And one day, I did find him.

It was late on a winter's night. A truck stopped at the shop. A man got out. He looked familiar. When he stepped into the light, I saw that it was not him, just someone who bore a strong resemblance. The man was tired. He asked for a cup of tea. As I served him, Sir, I felt this strange lightness. This sense of joy. When the man offered to pay, I did not take the money. The next day, it happened again. Every day, I would see someone, a complete stranger, a tired traveller, who reminded me of that officer. It was as if he was everywhere. And every time I served him tea, I felt a surge of sheer joy.

A month later, I quit my job at the shop and returned to those mountains. The shop owner was quite relieved. He had no use for a waiter who kept forgetting to present the bill to the customer. Now I am on my own. And I am at peace.

Here is your bus, Sir. No, no money... you were tired. All I offered you was a cup of tea. Maybe it was the best tea in all Garhwal. Maybe not. But I am happy I could do you this small service. Wish you a safe journey, Sir. May God be with you!

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Glossary

rickety (adj.)	:	structure or piece of equipment poorly made and likely to collapse
tremor (n)	:	a slight earthquake
devastation (n)	:	the state of being decayed or destroyed
haphazardly (adv.)	:	in a random manner
debris (n)	:	scattered pieces of rubbish or remains
white-shrouded (v)	:	wrap or dress (a body) in a shroud for burial
pyres (n)	:	a heap of burnable material, for burning a corpse as part of a funeral ceremony

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